

Θεαγένης ὁ Ῥηγῖνος

Theagenes of Rhegium and the Allegorical Reading of Homer

eul_aid: eow

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Δωρική](#) [Doric](#)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Συναγωγή](#) [Collection](#)
Affiliation: [Presocratic](#)

Theagenes of Rhegium was a Greek thinker from southern Italy, active in the sixth century BCE. He is recognized as the earliest known figure to practice the allegorical interpretation of texts, specifically the epic poetry of Homer. Living in the intellectually vibrant region of Magna Graecia, Theagenes wrote a treatise that is now lost.

In this work, he defended Homer against accusations of impiety by arguing that the gods and their conflicts in poems like the Iliad were not to be taken literally. According to ancient reports, he interpreted them as symbols for natural elements or human qualities, for instance reading a battle among gods as an allegory for the conflict between fire and water.

Modern scholars see Theagenes as a foundational figure in the history of literary criticism. His allegorical method provided a model for later philosophers and critics, such as the Stoics, who sought deeper philosophical meanings in traditional myths. His work represents an early attempt to reconcile poetic storytelling with emerging philosophical thought, securing his place as a significant, though fragmentarily known, precursor to later interpretive traditions.

Works (1)

- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 5 passages

Other Presocratic Authors

- [Ἀλκμαίων ὁ Κροτωνιάτης](#) · [Alcmaeon of Croton](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξαγόρας ὁ Κλαζομένιος](#) · [Anaxagoras of Clazomenae](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξίμανδρος ὁ Μιλήσιος](#) · [Anaximander of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξίμενης ὁ Μιλήσιος](#) · [Anaximenes of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξιμένους τοῦ Μιλησίου Ἐπιστολαί \(Ψευδο-Ἀναξίμενης\)](#) · [Anaximenes-pseudo Miletus Letters](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀρχέλαος ὁ Μιλήσιος ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Archelaus of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Κλεόβουλος ὁ Λίνδιος](#) · [Cleobulus of Lindos I](#) · 1 work
- [Δημόκριτος ὁ Ἀβδηρίτης](#) · [Democritus of Abdera](#) · 2 works
- [Διογένης ὁ Ἀπολλωνιάτης](#) · [Diogenes of Apollonia](#) · 2 works
- [Ἐμπεδοκλῆς ὁ Ἀκραγαντίνος](#) · [Empedocles of Acragas](#) · 3 works

- Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus · 2 works
- Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus II · 1 work